



MPC XL Field Manual

AKAI MPC XL · MPC 3.9 · JACKSON SOLOIST SL2 DX · LO-FI / CHILL / R&B

Get a loop out of the box tonight, then learn the machine properly. Written against Akai's own MPC 3.7 and 3.9 manuals, because MPC 3 rebuilt the data model and most tutorials older than 2025 describe a workflow that no longer exists. The guitar tab is the same idea for the Jackson.

Part 1: MPC XL

Day one, before you touch a pad

30 MINUTES

Boring, but the XL ships needing a firmware update and about 30 GB of content sits behind registration. Do this once.

01 Unbox properly

Peel the film off the 10.1" screen. The power supply is **two pieces**; check the box again before deciding something is missing.

02 Get on Wi-Fi

Shift + **Menu** opens Preferences (the button is printed *Menu / Prefs*) → **Wi-Fi** → On, pick your network.

Akai's FAQ admits a bug where the Wi-Fi password is rejected on first setup. If that happens, update from a USB stick or the desktop installer instead of fighting it.

03 Update the firmware (3.9.1 is current)

Preferences → **Info** → **Update** → **Online Update**. Later sections assume 3.8 or newer for the new effects and 3.9 for oscillators.

04 Register the unit

Serial is on the barcode on the **bottom**. It starts with "(21)" and you do not type the "(21)" part.

05 Log into your inMusic profile on the MPC itself

Preferences → **Activations**. This unlocks the **MPC Pro Pack** license (included with the XL, \$199 list for older MPCs) and activates Native Instruments Analog Dreams.

Pro Pack is Clip Matrix launching, Ableton Live project import, envelope-follower Q-Links (your sidechain), the Super warp algorithm, and four AIR plugins. If features look missing after activating, Akai's fix is deactivate, restart, reactivate.

06 Pick a content drive, then pull the packs and the 3.8 effects

Same Activations page, **Change** picks the download drive; internal is fine. Grab **Lo-Fi Breeze** (Jamie Wilder), **LoFi Boom Vol 1** (Marco Polo), **Classic Drum Machines**, and **F9 Orion** for dusty 90s workstation keys. Also download the 3.8 effects (Vinyl Emulation, Tape Emulation, Vintage, Color Compressor, Trigger FX); they are not on the machine until you do.

07 Connect Splice, if you have it

Preferences → **Splice** → Get Login Code, approve in a browser, choose a drive, Sync Files. Sorted by BPM, key, instrument and pack once it lands.

How the machine actually thinks

READ THIS ONCE

In MPC 2 and earlier, a *track* held notes and pointed at a separate *program* that held sounds. MPC 3 fused them. A track now is its sound; you pick the type when you make it, and that choice is the instrument.

```
PROJECT > everything, one file + a data folder
SEQUENCE > a loop with its own BPM, bars and time signature
TRACK > notes AND the sound, up to 128
```

Six track types, chosen at **+ New Track** in Main Mode. Tap the type icon beside the track number to change it later.

Drum	Samples (or, since 3.9, synth oscillators) on pads. 128 pads in 8 banks, 8 layers per pad. Your kit and your chops.
Keygroup	Samples mapped across a key range so they play chromatically. Up to 128 keygroups. A sampled Rhodes, a vocal you play as notes, an 808 from one sample.
Plugin	One instrument plugin: Fabric, Hype, Mellotron, Solina, Stage EP, TubeSynth, OPx-4, Odyssey, Bassline, Analog Dreams. 32 at once on the XL.
Audio	Recorded audio from an input, or resampled internally. 16 stereo audio tracks.
MIDI	Notes out the 5-pin MIDI ports to external gear.
CV	Control voltage to modular. Melodic, or Drum CV where any pad fires any CV port.

VOCABULARY THAT CHANGED

"Program Edit" is now **Track Edit**. "Sample Record" is now **Sampler**. Clip programs are gone as a type; clips live in Clip Matrix. "Drum Program" survives only as a savable kit file, so old kits still load. When a video says "assign this track to that program," it is pre-2025.

Your first lo-fi loop

ONE SITTING

The recipe: find four bars of something, chop it, play the chops in a new order, put drums under it, dirty the whole thing. Standalone, no computer.

01 Start a project and set the tempo low

New Project. Sequence BPM between 72 and 88, 4 bars.

Every sequence carries its own tempo. To lock everything to one number, tap the on-screen **SEQ/GBL** until it reads GBL, or use **Shift** + **Tap Tempo** (the button lights red for global).

02 Get a source sound in

From the packs: **Browse**, then the **Expansions** button beside Places and Content. Turn the browser's **Warp** toggle on so anything with an embedded tempo auditions at your project tempo.

From a record or a phone: turntable into the rear RCA inputs with the Phono/Line switch on Phono; phone or laptop over USB-C. Then **Shift** + **Sample Edit** opens the Sampler; set the **Input** field to match, arm, record.

From the Jackson: guitar into front **Inst 1**. Flip the Rear/Front switch under the Gain 1 knob to Front. Mic into the rear XLR needs Rear, and **+48V** only for a condenser.

That Rear/Front switch is the most-missed control on the machine. Plugged into the front and hearing nothing? That switch.

03 Set record level with the hardware knobs

Gain is on **Gain 1**, **Gain 2** and **3/4 Rec Gain**, not the screen. Watch the input meters and keep peaks out of the red. Turn **Dir/Main** toward Direct for zero-latency monitoring while recording, back to Main for playback.

In Sampler set **Threshold** low (Akai's tutorial uses -45 dB) and tap **Arm**. It waits for signal and starts itself.

Insert effects loaded in Sampler are printed permanently into the recording. Leave them empty until you mean it.

04 Chop it

Press **Chop** (dedicated button) or open Sample Edit and tap the Trim/Chop toggle bottom-left. Four modes:

BPM — bars, beats, Time Div 1/16. Even slices. [Start here](#).

Threshold — slices at transients; move the value until markers land on the hits, and raise

Min Time if one drum gets two slices.

Regions — N equal slices, no analysis.

Manual — tap **Slice+** during playback, or hit an unlit pad, to drop a marker where you hear it.

No "Transient" chop mode exists in MPC 3 despite older tutorials. Threshold is the transient mode. Since 3.7, if a sample already has slices the Chop button opens Manual so you do not destroy them.

05 Turn the chops into a playable kit

Shift + **Chop** (printed *Chop / Convert*) opens Convert or Assign Slices. Choose **New drum track using slices**. Chops land on pads 1–16 of a new drum track named after the sample plus "ch".

Tick **Create Events** and set **Bars** to have the original order laid into the sequence, so play gives you the loop back untouched and you rearrange from there.

"Using slices" points every pad at the one original sample instead of writing 16 files. Lighter on RAM, and you can still nudge slice boundaries.

06 Play the chops in a new order

Arm the sequence (on-screen **Rec Arm** in Main Mode, or the hardware **Rec Arm** in the channel strip for the selected track), press **Rec**, then **Play**, and hit pads. After one pass the machine flips into Overdub by itself so you layer instead of erase.

Hate the pass? **Undo** while still recording wipes that pass only. Hold **Erase** and press a pad during playback to erase that pad's notes live.

07 Add drums on a second track

+ New Track → Drum, load a kit. Pick a pad map and never change it, so your hands learn one layout (Akai's default kit puts a hi-hat on pad 9).

Hold **Note Repeat** and press a pad for rolls; rate at the bottom of the screen. **Shift** + **Note Repeat** latches.

08 Swing it, do not straighten it

Shift + **TC On/Off** opens Timing Correct. **Time Division** 1/16, **Swing** 54–58%. 50% is dead straight; 75% is the maximum.

Pull **Strength** under 100% so quantize drags your timing toward the grid instead of nailing it there.

This is the genre in one setting. Perfectly quantized lo-fi sounds like a stock loop; 55% swing at 80% strength sounds like a person.

09 Add keys or bass

+ New Track → Plugin. **Stage EP** or **Fabric Electric Piano** for Rhodes, **Mellotron** for tape strings, **Bassline** for low end. Or since 3.9 a Keygroup track with a Warm Sine oscillator is an instant 808 sub.

Press **Notes** to turn the pads into a scale or chord layout (Pad Perform). Set Type to **Chords**, a minor scale, and **1-3-5-7** for diatonic sevenths on 16 pads. It does nothing on drum tracks, by design.

10 Fix a tempo mismatch on purpose

Track Edit → Samples: **Warp** on plus **BPM Sync** on locks the sample to project tempo without changing pitch.

Want the slowed-tape sound? Leave **Warp** off and drop **Semi**. Length and pitch move together like a record slowing down. Often the better creative answer.

Super is the new high-quality algorithm, **Pro Ten** the workhorse, **Repitch** is varispeed. Warping is the biggest CPU cost on the machine, so bake finished pads with **Shift** + **Stem** (Flatten Pad).

11 Dirty it up

Build the chain in Lo-fi dirt. Short version: **Vinyl Emulation** or **AIR Flavor** on the sample track, a low-pass rolling off the top, gentle compression on the output.

12 Save, properly, right now

Save → **Project As**. Name it something you will recognize.

Plain **Project** overwrites your last save with no prompt (the manual says so). Auto-save is a preference you turn on yourself, and nothing in the manual suggests a save happens at shutdown.

Every button, and what Shift does to it

SEARCH THIS

Gray text on a button is its **Shift** function. Double-press either **Shift** and every button with a secondary function flashes for a few seconds.

Verified identical between the 3.7 and 3.9 manuals.

BUTTON	PRESS	SHIFT + PRESS
Menu	Mode grid	Preferences
Main	Main Mode	Track View
Sounds	Browse plugin presets, favorites, setlists	Favorites (the manual is inconsistent on whether Shift is needed; there is also a Favorites button)
Save	Save window	Save As
Browse	Browser	Pad Assign (the Sample Assign page)
Stem	Stems Pro separation on the selected sample	Flatten Pad (bake layers, inserts and warp to one sample)
Chop	Chop mode on the selected sample	Convert or Assign Slices
Sample Edit	Trim and chop	Sampler (record)
Grid Edit	Piano-roll grid	List Edit
Track Mute	Mute tracks from pads	MIDI Control mode
Pad Mute	Mute pads	XYFX
Arrange	Linear arranger	Sequence Edit window
Matrix	Clip Matrix	Launch Configuration
Mixer	Channel Mixer	Pad Mixer
Track Edit	Sound design for the current track	Track Settings
Next Seq	Queue the next sequence	Song Mode
Full Level	Every hit at 127	Set Level (a fixed custom velocity)
16 Levels	One pad across 16 with one parameter varying	To Keygroup: the selected drum sample becomes a playable keygroup track
Notes	Pad Perform on and off	Pad CTRL (pad aftertouch on and off)
Erase	Hold + pad during playback erases live; stopped, opens Erase window	Clear Track
Note Repeat	Hold for rolls	Latch
Copy	Copy pad to pads	Delete pad assignment
Q-Links	Q-Link Edit; hold for the mode picker	Learn: MIDI-learn the last touched control
Touch FX	Touch FX on the strip (XL only button)	Config
Touch Strip	Cycle strip modes; hold to pick on screen	Config

BUTTON	PRESS	SHIFT + PRESS
Pad Bank A-D	Banks A-D; double-press for E-H	Banks E-H
Set	Hold + step button 1-16 picks the step row's mode	Follow
Audition	Preview a step	Lock
Prev / Next	Step page	Nudge
Tap Tempo	Tap a tempo	Global tempo (red) vs sequence tempo (white)
Loop On	Loop the sequence or region	Punch In
Arrange / Clip	Cycles the recording destination	
Read/Write	Automation R (green) or W (red)	Clear automation
Metronome	Click on and off	Config: count-in, sound, volume, output
TC On/Off	Quantize on and off	Timing Correct window
Quantize	Quantize the track now	All tracks
Rec	Record	Recall: insert the notes you played while not recording
Over Dub	Layer without erasing	
Stop	Stop; double-press silences ringing audio	Return to start (or loop start, manual gives both)
Play / Play Start	Play from here / from the top	Play Start: toggle metronome
< > / << >>	Step / bar	Hold Locate + these: previous/next event, or start/end
Locate	Locate window: position, loop range, six named markers	
Undo	Undo (while recording: wipe this pass)	Redo
USB Select	Cycle USB audio input	Cycle backwards; hold to choose on screen

The XL hardware nobody explains

PANEL

Two of these are XL-exclusive (the channel strip and the Touch FX button). The expressive pads, step buttons and touch strip are shared with the MPC Live III, but no earlier MPC has them.

RIGHT SIDE, XL ONLY

Channel Control strip

Akai markets it as "XL Channel Command"; the manual calls it Channel Control. A hardware channel strip with its own OLED and meter. Press **Tracks**, **Outputs**, **Returns** or **Submixes** to pick a class, step with **TRK-** / **TRK+**, then arm, mute, solo, open inserts (**Track FX**) or set level with the knob, without opening the mixer.

16 PADS

3D sensing

Each pad reads velocity, pressure and finger position and is split into four quadrants. Per layer, Track Edit → Samples → Tune/Mix has an **MPCe** toggle so a corner fires a different layer. The pad's second Effects page assigns four **articulations** (flams, rolls, buzzes) to the corners. Q-Link Edit → MPCe Pads maps X, Y and pressure to any parameter, drum tracks only.

BOTTOM ROW

16 step buttons

Hold **Set** + a step button: 1 Drum Seq, 2 Note Seq, 3 Step Edit, 4 Note Length, 5 Last Step, 6 Automation, 7 Clip Launch, 8 Row Launch, 9 Track Select, 10 Track Arm, 11 Track Mute, 12 Pad Mute, 13 Next Seq, 14 Q-Link Pad Grid, 15 Visuals, 16 Edit Actions. Step Edit gives per-step velocity, ratchet, probability and nudge; probability on hats is how they stop repeating identically.

LEFT EDGE

Touch strip + Touch FX

Touch Strip cycles modes: Q-Link 1–16, Pad Level, Track Level, Notes, Note Strum, Pitch Bend, Mod Wheel, Sustain, Expression, Crossfader. **Touch FX** (own button on the XL) drops a 20-preset performance effect on a track, return, submix or output: manual and beat-synced filters, beat repeat, tape stop, delays, phaser, comb filter, washout, granulator, flanger.

17 OLEDS

Q-Link knobs

Sixteen knobs, each with a display showing what it controls; touching one enlarges the value. On the Live III these are four banks of four; on the XL all sixteen are physical, so "cycle Q-Link banks" in tutorials does not apply to you. Hold **Q-Links** for the mode picker: Screen, Project, Track, Pad Scene, Pad Parameter, Track FX Rack, Volume, Pan, Sends, Step Sequencer.

INPUTS

Front vs rear

Two rear combo XLR/TRS with preamps and a single **+48V** for both. Two front instrument jacks. Each **Gain** knob has a **Rear/Front** switch beneath it choosing which of those it feeds. Inputs 3/4 are rear TRS or RCA with a **Phono/Line** switch. **Stereo/Mono** puts a single mic or guitar in both ears.

WHY YOUR KNOB MOVES DID NOT RECORD

Touch strip moves and pad X/Y gestures write into the sequence only when automation is set to W. **Read/Write** turns red. Perform, then set it back to R or you will keep overwriting the moves you liked.

Pad sound design in Track Edit

DRUM TRACKS

Press **Track Edit** on a drum track, then hit a pad to select it. Tabs run along the bottom; tapping some tabs again cycles their pages. The location icon top-left sets whether edits hit the current pad, several, or all.

Global	Sample Play: One Shot (whole sample), Note On (only while held, this is what makes a chop stop when you let go), Note Off. Pad Polyphony: Mono kills the previous hit when you retrigger; this is the "voice overlap" control, there is no separate choke field. Mute Group 1–32 for open and closed hats. Simultaneous Play fires up to four other pads (layered kicks). Layer Play: Cycle, Velocity, Random, or Crossfade by finger position.
Samples, page 1	Start and End markers (Q-Links in Screen mode grab these), Reverse, Loop, Slice (All / Pad / a slice number), Slice Motion (Increment or Random through the slices on each hit), Pad Loop (needs Sample Play Note On <i>and</i> Slice = Pad), Warp, BPM Sync, Semi, Fine, Algorithm. Partial Preset saves the whole pad's synth state to reuse elsewhere.
Samples, page 2–4	Tune/Mix per layer (Semi, Fine, Level, Pan, MPCe quadrant). Velocity per layer (Vel Start / Vel End: put a harder snare on 100–127 only). Random: per-layer pitch, level, pan and start-offset randomization; on hats this is cheap humanizing.
Envelopes	Amp page: Pad Level, Pan, amp envelope, velocity to amp. Drum pads use AD or AHDS (AD has a Decay From Start / Decay From End type; the latter holds full level, then decays). Note On pads use ADSR. Filter page: Type , Cutoff , Reso , filter envelope and depth, velocity to cutoff. Pitch page: pitch envelope for the "thump" on kicks.
Filter types	Low-pass, high-pass, band-pass, band-stop and boost in 1, 2, 6 and 8-pole flavors; Model 1–3 analog-style (Model 3 is the aggressive one); Vocal formant filters; and MPC3000 LPF , the 12 dB/octave filter from the 1994 machine. That last one on a chop is a very short route to the right sound.
Effects, page 2	Drum FX: up to eight simplified per-pad effects with no insert slot used: Ring Mod, Bit Crush, Decimator, Tube Drive, Soft and Hard Clipper, Low Pass, High Pass, Rectifier, Bass Enhancer, Wave Folder, Gain. Page 1 has the four inserts, sends, and an Akai folder icon that loads factory FX racks including a LoFi rack.
Mods, LFO, Mod Matrix	Velocity to sample start, cutoff, pitch, pan. Two LFOs to pitch, filter, amp, pan (a slow sine on pitch at tiny depth is tape wobble). A 32-slot mod matrix; since 3.7 Slice is a target, so velocity can pick the chop.

Flatten Pad

Shift + **Stem**. Renders all layers at full velocity through the pad's inserts and warp onto layer 1 as a plain sample. Set an Audio Tail of a couple of seconds. This is how you stop paying CPU for a sound that is finished.

One sample into a playable instrument

Select the pad holding a single note (a Rhodes stab, a bass note, a vocal "oh") and press **Shift** + **16 Levels**. A new keygroup track appears and the pads switch to Pad Perform. In Track Edit for that keygroup, set the Root Note to the pitch you sampled and it plays in tune across the keys. The Sampler's Keep window and Sample Edit Trim both have a Root Note field too.

Making it feel like a person played it

TECHNIQUE

Swing 54–58%	Timing Correct. 50% straight, 75% ceiling. Apply to 1/16s on hats and chops; consider leaving the kick straight for contrast.
Strength below 100%	Partial quantize. Notes get pulled toward the grid without landing on it. The single most useful humanizing control on the machine.
Shift Timing	Also in Timing Correct, in ticks. Push a whole track a few ticks late and it sits behind the beat. Snares and keys.
Humanize	Edit menu in Arrange, Grid or Clip editing. Randomizes timing (Amount in pulses, plus Eagerness), note length and velocity. Blunter than Strength; use lightly.
16 Levels	Spreads one pad across all 16 with one parameter varying: Velocity, Tune, Filter, Layer, Slice, Articulation, Attack, Decay, Probability or Ratchet. Tune across 16 pads turns one chop into a melody; Slice across 16 pads is a chop keyboard.
Note Repeat and Arp	Hold Note Repeat , pick a rate at the bottom. On a plugin or keygroup track the same window has Action : Arp, Note Repeat, Rhythm, or Pattern (hold one note, get a transposed phrase).
Pad Perform	Notes . Type Chromatic, Notes, Chords, Chromatic Chords, Progressions, Custom. Chords in a scale: 1-3-5, 1-4-5, 1-2-5, 1-3-5-7, 1-3-5-7b. Grid View can Convert to Progression from a MIDI track you already played, and user .progression files go in a root-level Progressions folder on a drive.
Retro Rec	Pull-down menu at the top of the screen, or Shift + Rec (Recall). Captures MIDI you played while <i>not</i> recording. For when you accidentally play the best version of the part.

Four insert slots at every level: pad, keygroup, track, submix, output.
Plus four sends into four returns, each with its own four inserts. Dirt at the track level, glue at the output.

3.8, DOWNLOAD FIRST Vinyl Emulation Akai's own words: noise, dust, wobble, age. Added in 3.8 alongside Tape Emulation (wow, noise, pitch) and Vintage (classic hardware-sampler warmth and saturation). All three must be downloaded through Preferences → Activations before they show up. Start here now that they exist.	THE CLASSIC AIR Flavor EQ simulations of radios, phones and tape, with Vinyl Distortion and Vinyl Noise as separate 0–100% controls. Noise gives the clicks and pops. Belongs on the sample track.
DESTRUCTION AIR Lo-Fi Bit depth to 1 bit, sample rate to 500 Hz, clip, rectify, noise modulation. The Anti-Alias section is off by default, which is why it sounds so harsh out of the box; turn it on for the musical version.	CHEAPER CRUNCH Decimator vs Resampler Same idea, one difference: Decimator does no anti-alias filtering, Resampler does. Decimator for digital grit, Resampler when the sample-rate drop should hide behind the sound. Both also exist as per-pad Drum FX.
SPACE Delay Tape Sync Tape loop and multi-head echo emulation, tempo-locked. A quarter-note tape delay at low feedback under keys is most of the genre's ambience. AIR Reverb Pro (Pro Pack) for the room.	TOP-END CONTROL AIR Vintage Filter Roll the highs off the sample track until it sounds like it came through a wall. AIR Kill EQ for live band-kills on the touch strip.
GRIT AIR Diode Clip Akai's description: "subtle grit to drum breaks." AIR Tube Drive if you want it warmer and louder. Color Compressor (3.8) for saturated compression in one box.	GLUE Output inserts Compressor (Opto is gentlest), then AIR Limiter on the output, not the track. Output inserts are the documented place for mastering-style processing. AIR Visual EQ4 to see what you are doing.

Sidechain pump with an envelope follower

PRO PACK

Two ways. The quick one is the **Mother Ducker** pair: Mother Ducker Input on the kick track, Mother Ducker on the chords. The flexible one is the Pro Pack envelope follower, which can push any parameter, not just volume.

01 Open Q-Link Edit and pick a follower

Press **Q-Links**, tap the **Envelope Follower / LFO** tab. **Control** picks one of 16 followers. Tap **On**.

02 Point it at the kick

Envelope Source = the drum track, or better, the specific kick Pad on it. Tap point **Pre-Inserts** or **Post-Fader**.

03 Shape the envelope

Short **Attack**, **Decay** roughly the length of the pump you want. **Gate** and **Hyst** stop it triggering on hats bleeding through.

04 Learn the target

Tap the yellow **Learn**, go to the chord track's volume in the Channel Mixer (or a filter cutoff on its insert), move it, come back, tap Learn again.

05 Flip it

In the inspector on the right, tap **Flip** so a loud kick pushes the volume *down*. Set the two Parameter Range knobs so the duck is musical rather than a mute.

Source can also be an internal **LFO** (free-running or reset on play) for a tempo-free pump with no kick at all.

Looper, resampling, and stems

MENU PAGE 2

Looper

Record and overdub audio in real time, then export the loop as a sample. Set **Input** (a physical input, USB, or **Resample L+R** to record what the machine itself is playing), **Bars**, **Sync** to the transport, **Record To** Overdub. Arm with Rec, play; each pass adds a layer. **Export to Track**, or **Shift** + **Export to Pad** which opens the Keep window with a pad assignment.

Lo-fi resample trick

Input = Resample L+R. Play your plugin chords through Vinyl Emulation and a low-pass, capture two bars in the Looper, export to a pad, then chop it like a record. The keys stop sounding like a plugin.

Stems Pro	XL-exclusive (needs the 8-core CPU). Select a sample, press Stem . Toggle Vocals / Bass / Drums / Other , pick a destination track. Assign to Pad on puts the four stems on the first four layers of that pad; off drops them into the sample pool. Uncheck Use trimmed sample to keep your slices.
Sampler methods	Besides plain record: Pad Tap (press a pad, it records straight to it; press another to move on) and Pad Hold (hold = record, release = stop). Drum tracks only. Fastest way to load a drum kit from a record.
Auto Sampler	Keyboard icon beside Record in the Sampler. Captures a plugin or external synth preset note by note into a keygroup, with velocity layers and loop points. Turn a heavy plugin into a light keygroup and free the CPU.

From a loop to an actual song

ARRANGE + EXPORT

Three ways to arrange, and they coexist. Pick one while learning.

Arrange Mode	Start here. A real linear timeline. Record a performance into it, punch in and out, six named locate markers, loop a region. Since 3.9: cut, copy, paste, duplicate with the loop brace, Insert Blank Bars, Insert Clip Row.
Song Mode	Shift + Next Seq . A playlist of up to 999 steps, each a sequence plus a repeat count. Stop playback before entering it. Convert > Seq flattens the song into one sequence.
Clip Matrix	Matrix . Part of Pro Pack. An 8×8 launch grid, one column per track, one clip per track at a time. Rows carry Follow Actions so a clip decides what plays next. For performing the arrangement rather than drawing it.

Exporting: **Save** → Audio Mixdown

What gets exported	From Main Mode, the current sequence only . From Song Mode, the whole song. Catches everyone once.
Audio Tail	At least 2 seconds or reverb and delay tails get cut off the end.
Stems	Render Source → Separate Tracks . Every pad must have its output routed to Track (the default, Pad Mixer → I/O) or it is missing from the stems. With a drum track selected, Drum Pads as Stems renders one file per pad. Since 3.8, Drum Track as MPC Sample file too.
Format	WAV, AIFF, MP3, FLAC or OGG. 24-bit, 44.1 kHz is the sane default and what Akai recommends.

To a DAW

Ableton Live Set writes a real .ALS. Or set tracks to USB Out pairs in Channel Mixer → I/O and record 24 channels live over USB-C (needs the XL driver from inMusic Software Center).

New since the box shipped

3.8 AND 3.9

3.9

Oscillators on pads and keygroups

Track Edit → the Samples tab is now **Samples/Oscs**. Per layer, flip **Sample / OSC** and pick Warm Sine, Digital Sine, Saw/Square, Pulse, Noise, FM2, RM3, Algorithmic, Single-Cycle or Wavetable. Every type has Decay and Start Phase. A Warm Sine on a keygroup with a short pitch envelope is an 808 without sampling one. Some sets need "Get Oscillator Content" in Activations.

3.9

Time signature per sequence and clip

A field in Main Mode's Sequence section. Also Arrange cut/copy/paste/duplicate with the loop brace, and Insert Clip Row.

3.8

Five effects

Vinyl Emulation, Tape Emulation, Vintage, Color Compressor, Trigger FX (a performance stutter/filter/delay). Download via Activations. The 3.9 manual's effects appendix does not describe them yet; the release notes do.

3.9.1

Known issues

Rare blank WAV from Audio Mixdown (check the file before you delete the project), cancelling a save can fail and flash the pads, held notes stop when you change sequence during playback.

Traps

SAVE YOURSELF THE HOUR

Project overwrites silently

Project overwrites your last save with no confirmation. **Project As** makes a version. Auto-save is off unless you turn it on in Preferences → Project Load/Save.

A project is two things

Name.xpj plus a hidden Name_[ProjectData] folder. They travel together or the project opens with missing samples. Akai's advice for external drives: a root Projects folder with nothing else in it, and keep 1–3 GB free on the internal drive.

Undo lives in RAM

When the low-memory warning appears, undo may already be gone. Menu → Project → Purge → Unused Samples before it gets there. Plugins like Studio Strings and Fabric load whole libraries into RAM; bounce plugin tracks to audio when they are done.

Loading is not assigning	The browser's Load to Pool puts a sample in the pool, not on a pad. With a drum pad selected, plain Load goes straight to that pad. Or Shift + Browse for Sample Assign: press a pad until it lights green, then double-tap the sample or drag it. Shift-drag targets a specific layer.
Samples get converted on load	Everything becomes full-quality uncompressed audio inside the project, so a folder of MP3s can blow the RAM. Load fewer files. Browser Options has Clear unused samples on load for swapping kits cleanly.
Sampler and Looper effects are permanent	Inserts on those two print into the recording. No undo later.
USB-C is for the computer	MIDI controllers and class-compliant interfaces go in the USB-A ports. External interfaces are capped at 44.1 kHz.
Controller Mode closes your project	Save first. "Looking for computer" on the screen just means it is in Controller Mode, not that it is broken.
Importing old MPC 2 projects	Save a copy first. Where several MPC 2 tracks shared one program, one becomes the real track and the rest become MIDI tracks pointed at it.
Pad Loop needs two settings	Sample Play = Note On <i>and</i> Slice = Pad. One without the other does nothing.
Disk streaming is off	Preferences → Audio/Export, needs a restart. Akai recommends an SSD in the internal SATA bay and pointing the Temporary File Location at it. Only worth it once projects get huge.

When it breaks

AKAI SUPPORT ANSWERS

Pads make no sound, kit loaded	Preferences → MIDI/Sync → make sure Track is enabled for the input port MPC Pads . Then check Pad Mute / Track Mute (orange pads) and that the track is not audio-muted in the mixer.
Cannot hear the input	Sampler Monitor to In. Then the Rear/Front switch for that Gain knob, the Phono/Line switch for 3/4, the gain knob itself, and Dir/Main toward Direct. Audio tracks have Monitor In / Auto / Merge in the I/O tab.
Latency	Akai's answer is direct monitoring: Monitor In on the Sampler or Looper, or the Dir/Main knob, both taken before the machine's processing. An external USB interface must be 44.1 kHz at a 128-sample buffer.

Low memory or project will not load	Un-arm audio tracks, Purge unused samples, then save, then New Project or power-cycle. A project too big for RAM loads with samples shown as a waveform and a red minus; free memory and use Load To Memory from the Project window.
Computer does not see it	Firmware and desktop MPC 3 must be on matching point versions, with the XL driver installed from inMusic Software Center. Direct USB-C, different cable. macOS 13, 15 or 26; Windows 10 or 11.
Drives	exFAT, FAT32, NTFS and EXT4 read and write; HFS+ read-only. Shift + Format Drive in the Browser formats to exFAT and wipes everything on it.

My notes

SAVED WITH YOUR PROGRESS

Part 2: Jackson Soloist SL2 DX

What you actually own

JACKSON AMERICAN SERIES SOLOIST SL2 DX

This is a US-built (Corona, California) neck-through shred guitar aimed, in the reviews' own words, at advanced players. That is fine. A well-made guitar with low action and light strings is *easier* to learn on than a cheap one, with one exception you need to understand before you touch a tuning peg: the bridge floats, and the strings are clamped at both ends.

Neck and board	3-piece maple, neck-through-body, graphite reinforced. 25.5" scale, 24 jumbo stainless steel frets (they will not wear), ebony board with a 12"-16" compound radius: rounder near the nut for chords, flatter up high for bends. Glow-in-the-dark side dots.
Pickups	Seymour Duncan JB (TB-4) at the bridge, hot and bright, the classic rock/metal humbucker. Seymour Duncan '59 (SH-1N) at the neck, warm and vintage. One volume, one tone, 5-way blade.
Bridge	Floyd Rose 1500 Series double-locking tremolo with a locking nut (confirmed: yours is the trem version, not the HT hardtail). The 1500 is the import 1000-series bridge with stainless screws and a push-in arm. Two things follow from it: daily tuning is fine tuners only, and string changes are one at a time. Next section.
Strings	Ships with nickel-plated steel .009-.042 . Stay on exactly that gauge for the first few months; changing gauge on a Floyd means rebalancing springs.
Strap buttons	Dunlop dual-locking. A normal strap will not fit without the supplied adapters or Straplok ends. Worth sorting before you try to stand up with it.
Output	Standard 1/4" jack, passive electronics, no battery.

The 5-way switch, from Jackson's own wiring sheet

POSITION	WHAT IS ON	USE IT FOR
1 (toward bridge)	Bridge JB humbucker	High gain, palm-muted power chords, everything the guitar was built for
2	Bridge outer coil + neck inner coil	Clean, funky, "Strat-like" sparkle; lower output, keep the amp clean
3	Both humbuckers	Thick balanced cleans, classic-rock crunch

POSITION	WHAT IS ON	USE IT FOR
4	Bridge inner coil + neck outer coil	Same as 2, slightly different flavor
5 (toward neck)	Neck '59 humbucker	Warm cleans, chill chords, lead lines. Roll the tone knob to 6–7 for warmer still

All five positions are hum-cancelling. For lo-fi and R&B chords into the MPC you will live on 5, and rolling the volume knob back to 7 on a driven amp cleans it up before you learn to switch channels.

Floyd Rose survival

READ BEFORE TUNING

The bridge pivots on two posts. String tension pulls it toward the neck; springs in the back cavity pull it the other way. When balanced, the baseplate sits parallel to the body and the bar can dive or pull up. Because it is a balance, **changing any one string's tension changes every other string's pitch**, and a broken string throws the whole thing sharp and tips the bridge into the body.

01 Daily tuning: fine tuners only

Once the three nut clamps are locked, **never turn the headstock tuners**; you will snap strings. Tune with the six fine tuners on the bridge. Clockwise sharpens, counterclockwise flattens. A clip-on tuner on the headstock works fine.

If a fine tuner runs out of travel: unlock that string's nut clamp with the 3 mm hex, back the fine tuner to the middle of its range, tune at the headstock, re-lock, touch up with the fine tuner.

02 Full retune, Floyd Rose's own procedure

Loosen the three nut clamps. Set all six fine tuners to mid-range. Tune from low E up. Re-check low E: if it went flat, tune the first five strings slightly sharp and the high E to pitch; if sharp, the reverse. Repeat until they stop moving. Check the baseplate is parallel to the body. Lock the nut. Final touch with fine tuners.

If the plate tilts up, the springs are too loose: backplate off, spring-claw screws clockwise a quarter turn, retune, repeat. Tilted back, counterclockwise.

03 Changing strings without drama

One string at a time, same gauge. Per string: loosen that nut clamp, loosen the saddle screw (3 mm hex), pull the old string, **cut the ball end off** the new one, seat the plain end in the saddle, snug the screw (do not overtighten), thread the locking tuner, tune, stretch the string along its length and retune until it holds, center the fine tuner, lock the nut, final tune.

Tools: 3 mm hex, wire cutters, string winder, tuner. Pros block the bridge with a cloth-wrapped wood block and change all six at once; do that only after you have done it one at a time a few times.

04 Consider blocking the trem for now

Free option: with the guitar in tune, wedge a small wood block or a stack of picks between the tremolo block and the cavity wall on the bridge side so the bridge cannot move, and tighten the springs slightly so it stays seated. Now it tunes like a hardtail, bends do not drag the other strings flat, a broken string does not detune the rest, and string changes are painless. Reversible in two minutes.

A Tremol-No (about \$60–80) does the same with thumbwheels and no wood. If you never use the bar, keep it blocked.

Plugging in

AMP OR MPC

INTO THE MPC XL

Front Inst 1, switch to Front

Cable into the front **Inst 1** jack, flip the Rear/Front switch under **Gain 1** to Front, **Stereo/Mono** to Mono. Main Mode → New Track → Audio. In the track's I/O tab: Audio In = Input 1, Monitor = Auto. Raise Gain 1 until it peaks without clipping. **Dir/Main** toward Direct while playing.

Sound On Sound's verdict: clean guitar through the built-in effects is acceptable, high-gain tones are not. For chill chords into a beat it is exactly right. For metal, use an amp.

SMALL STUFF

Picks and a tuner

Medium picks around 0.73–0.88 mm to start; go thicker later for lead. A clip-on tuner (Snark, D'Addario) or the tuner in the Katana. Keep nails on the fretting hand short.

A REAL AMP

Boss Katana-50 Gen 3

Guitar World's beginner pick and the sensible one for a JB-equipped Jackson: a clean channel for chords, a "Brown" high-gain channel, a built-in tuner, a headphone jack for the apartment, app editing. About \$300. Silent option: a Positive Grid Spark Neo Core headphone amp, about \$100.

Holding it

WEEK 1

Sitting	Guitar on the right leg, both feet flat, back straight, shoulders level. The waist of the Soloist body sits on your thigh. If your fretting wrist bends sharply, angle the neck up a little.
Standing	Strap so the guitar sits where it does when seated. Too low looks cool and makes chords harder. Sort the Dunlop strap locks first.
Pick grip	Pick between the pad of the thumb and the side of the index finger, index pointing toward the tip. Expose a few millimeters for single notes, more for strumming. Hold firmly, not tightly; the pick should be able to give a little when it hits a string.
Fretting hand	Thumb on the middle of the back of the neck, roughly opposite your middle finger. Play on the finger tips , arched, so you do not touch the string below. Press right behind the fret wire , on the headstock side, not in the middle of the space. Wrist fairly straight, elbow relaxed away from your body.
Finger numbers	1 index, 2 middle, 3 ring, 4 pinky. T for thumb. Every diagram below uses these.
Tuning	Standard: E A D G B E, thick to thin. Strings are numbered 1 = thin high E through 6 = thick low E. On this guitar, daily tuning is fine tuners only (see above).

Reading chord boxes and tab

2 MINUTES

CHORD BOX Vertical = strings, horizontal = frets Six vertical lines, thick low E on the left. Horizontal lines are frets; the thick bar at the top is the nut. Dots show where fingers go, the number in the dot is the finger. O above a string means play it open, X means do not play it. The diagrams below are drawn exactly this way.	TAB Top line = thin string Six lines again but flipped: the top line is the 1st (thin E) string. Numbers are fret numbers, 0 is open, stacked numbers are played together. Symbols you will meet: h hammer-on, p pull-off, b bend, / slide, ~ vibrato, PM palm mute, x muted.
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NOTATION SHORTHAND

x-x-0-2-3-2

Six numbers, low E to high E, fret per string.
This is how the chords are written in the tables.
D major is x-x-0-2-3-2: skip the two thickest strings, D open, then frets 2, 3, 2.

The eight chords that unlock hundreds of songs

JUSTINGUITAR GRADE 1 ORDER

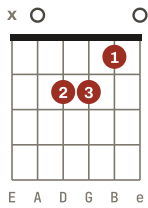
Learn them in this order, two at a time, and do not touch F until month three. Check each chord by picking the strings one at a time: every one should ring. If one buzzes, the finger is too far from the fret; if one is dead, a neighboring finger is leaning on it.

Weeks 1-2

D	A	E
x x 0 2 3 2	x 0 2 2 2 0	0 2 2 1 0 0
Skip the two thick strings. A tidy triangle.	Justin's 2-1-3 grip keeps finger 1 near where D needs it.	All six strings. The fullest sounding open chord.

Weeks 3-4

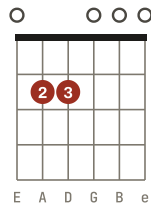
Am



x-0-2-2-1-0

The E shape moved down one string. Skip the low E.

Em

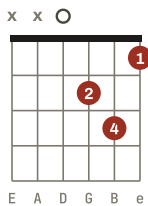


0-2-2-0-0-0

E with finger 1 lifted.
Two fingers, six strings.

Weeks 5-8

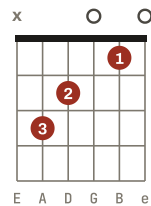
Dm



x-x-0-2-3-1

Finger 4 on the B string (use 3 if it will not reach yet).

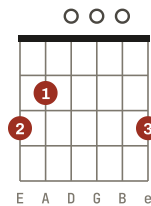
C



x-3-2-0-1-0

Lean finger 3 slightly to mute the low E.

G



3-2-0-0-0-3

Hack while learning:
only fingers 2 and 3,
finger 2 laid flat to mute the A.

Month 3 and beyond

F

1-3-3-2-1-1

Barre finger 1 across fret 1. Month three, not week one.

E5

0-2-2-x-x-x

Power chord. Strum strings 6, 5, 4 only.

A5

x-0-2-2-x-x

Power chord. Strum strings 5, 4, 3 only.

Anchor fingers save you: going D to A, finger 1 can stay near fret 2. Going E to Am, the whole shape moves down one string without changing. Going Am to Em, lift finger 1. Practice the transitions, not the chords.

One-minute changes

THE DRILL THAT MAKES CHORDS USABLE

Pick two chords. Start the timer. Switch back and forth for sixty seconds and count every change (D to A to D is two). Do not strum, just land the shape. Write the number down every day; the number going up is the whole point. Grade 1 target is **30 a minute** on any pair, 60 is a stretch goal. This widget counts for you and keeps the log.

Strumming

RHYTHM FIRST, CHORDS SECOND

Weeks 1-3: four down-strums per bar, one per beat, with a metronome at 60-80 BPM. Strum from the wrist, not the elbow, and keep the hand moving even on beats you skip. Then learn the one pattern that covers most pop and rock, which JustinGuitar calls "Old Faithful."

OLD FAITHFUL, ONE BAR OF 4/4



Down on 1. Down-up on 2. **Miss the strings on 3** but keep the hand going down. Up on the "and" of 3. Down-up on 4. Count it out loud: "one, two and, and, four and." Grade 1 pass is this pattern clean at 80 BPM.

Power chords and palm muting

THIS IS A JACKSON

Two notes, no third, so they are neither major nor minor and sound huge with gain. Switch position 1, tone up, amp on the driven channel. The

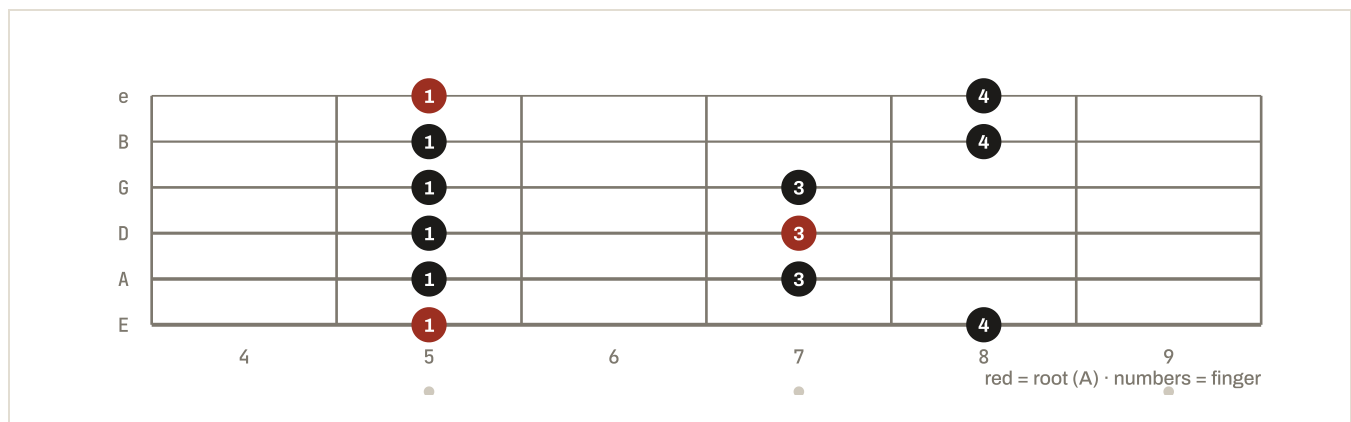
shapes are movable: learn one, slide it, and you know all twelve.

Root on the 6th string	Finger 1 on string 6 at fret n , finger 3 on string 5 at $n+2$, finger 4 on string 4 at $n+2$ (or finger 3 flattened across both). G5 is 3-5-5-x-x-x, A5 is 5-7-7-x-x-x. Strum only those three strings; let the underside of finger 1 rest on the thin strings to mute them.
Root on the 5th string	Same shape one string down: x- n -($n+2$)-($n+2$)-x-x. C5 is x-3-5-5, D5 is x-5-7-7.
Open shapes	E5 = 0-2-2-x-x-x, A5 = x-0-2-2-x-x. Drawn in the chord section above.
Palm muting	Rest the edge of the picking-hand palm on the strings right where they leave the bridge saddles. On a Floyd that is on the saddle blocks themselves; too far forward and it chokes the note dead. All downstrokes. Lift the palm off for the accented hits.
Riffs that teach it	Iron Man (root-6 power chords with slides), Enter Sandman (open low E with palm mutes), You Really Got Me (fast power-chord shifts). Lessons for all three are on JustinGuitar and Andy Guitar.

Your first scale: A minor pentatonic, box 1

MONTH 3

A "box" is a fret window where every string has exactly two notes, so you memorize a picture and slide it. This one lives at frets 5–8 with the root A on string 6 fret 5. Slide the whole shape to fret 3 and it is G minor pentatonic; fret 7, B minor. Finger 1 takes fret 5, finger 3 fret 7, finger 4 fret 8.



Practice: start and end on the low root, slow, with the metronome. Ascend, descend, then improvise over any A minor or C major backing track, or over your own lo-fi loop in A minor coming out of the MPC. This scale over a swung beat is where the two halves of this manual meet.

Twelve weeks, twenty minutes a day

CHECK THEM OFF

Every session: 1 minute tuning, 2 minutes finger stretches and a 1-2-3-4 crawl on one string, 5 minutes on the chord of the week, 4 minutes of one-minute changes, 4 minutes strumming with the metronome, 4 minutes playing an actual song. Short daily beats long weekly; calluses need repetition, not heroics.

01 Weeks 1–2: D, A, E and down-strums

One-minute changes on D ↔ A, D ↔ E, A ↔ E. Four downstrums per bar at 60 BPM. Song: Lay Down Sally or Stir It Up (A, D, E).

02 Weeks 3–4: Am, Em, first riff

E ↔ Am is the same grip moved over. Smoke on the Water on two strings as the first riff. Songs: Sing, Moves Like Jagger.

03 Weeks 5–6: Dm, Old Faithful, metronome

Dm uses finger 4 or 3 on the B string. Old Faithful at 60, then 70 BPM. Changes above 20 a minute on the first pairs.

04 Weeks 7–8: C

Finger 3 leans slightly to mute the low E. Songs: Eleanor Rigby (Em, C), Get Lucky.

05 Weeks 9–10: G and faster changes

Start with the two-finger G hack (finger 2 on fret 3 of the low E laid flat to mute the A, finger 3 on fret 3 of the high E). Push changes toward 30.

06 Weeks 11–12: consolidate, power chords, the box

Five songs you can play through. First power chords with palm muting. A minor pentatonic box 1 over your own MPC loop. Then start on F.

Songs, by what they teach

FREE VIDEO LESSONS EXIST FOR ALL OF THESE

SONG	CHORDS OR TECHNIQUE	WHERE
Lay Down Sally	Eric Clapton. A, D, E	JustinGuitar Module 2
Stir It Up	Bob Marley. A, D, E	JustinGuitar Module 2
Sing	Ed Sheeran. Am/Em groove	JustinGuitar Module 3
Moves Like Jagger	Maroon 5. Minor chords, one-chord groove	JustinGuitar Module 3
Eleanor Rigby	The Beatles. Em, C	JustinGuitar Module 5

SONG	CHORDS OR TECHNIQUE	WHERE
Get Lucky	Daft Punk. Four-chord loop	JustinGuitar Module 5
Smoke on the Water	Deep Purple. Two-string riff, the classic first one	JustinGuitar, Guitar World
Seven Nation Army	The White Stripes. Single string, sliding up the neck	JustinGuitar, Andy Guitar
Iron Man	Black Sabbath. Root-6 power chords, slides, palm mute	JustinGuitar Grade 2
Enter Sandman	Metallica. Open E, palm muting, bridge pickup	Andy Guitar

Pain, calluses, and the mistakes everyone makes

2 TO 4 WEEKS

Fingertips	Sore for the first 2–4 weeks, then calluses form and it stops. Short sessions, daily. Do not press harder than needed: press lighter until the note buzzes, then add a hair. Sharp pain in a joint or wrist is not normal; stop and fix the posture.
Muted strings	Almost always a finger that is flat instead of on its tip, or a thumb that has crept over the top of the neck. Thumb behind, fingers arched, nails short.
Buzzing	Finger too far from the fret. Slide it up until it is just behind the wire.
Bent wrist	Raise the neck, bring the elbow in, or raise the strap. A sharply bent fretting wrist is how people hurt themselves.
Practicing fast and sloppy	Slow with a metronome beats fast without one every time. Speed is a side effect of clean.
Starting with solos	Guitar World's number one beginner mistake. Chords and rhythm first; the pentatonic box in month three is early enough.
Old strings	Dead strings sound dull and make everything harder. On a Floyd, change them one at a time and same gauge (see survival section).

My notes

SAVED WITH YOUR PROGRESS

Sources. Akai's own documentation for MPC 3.7 and 3.9 and the XL, Akai support articles, and published reviews. Where a tutorial conflicts with this, the manual wins. Guitar material follows JustinGuitar's Grade 1 structure, Jackson's spec sheet, and Floyd Rose's own tuning instructions.

- [MPC Live III / MPC XL User Guide v3.9](#) · [v3.7 mirror](#)
- [MPC 3.8 release notes](#) · [3.9](#) · [release notes index](#)
- [Akai: MPC XL FAQ](#) · [Getting Started](#) · [MPC 3 FAQ](#) · [Pro Pack](#) · [Included content](#)
- [Akai: pads make no sound](#) · [low memory](#) · [backing up projects](#) · [recording a guitar](#)
- [Sound On Sound: MPC XL review](#) · [MusicRadar review](#) · [Sweetwater quickstart](#)

- [Jackson: American Series Soloist SL2 DX](#) · [Guitar World review](#) · [Floyd Rose: tuning instructions](#) · [Sweetwater: restringing a Floyd Rose](#)
- [JustinGuitar Beginner Grade 1](#) · [Guitar World: beginner lessons](#) · [Fender: holding a pick](#) · [Healthline: calluses](#)